

- A further **visual binary opposition** is created between the dreamlike sequences with dramatic images, music and the rich colour palette, and the reality conveyed through ambient lighting and the strident sound of the alarm clock.
- Animated and archive footage are included in opposition to real-life actions to introduce humour and reinforce the narrative.
- The **on-screen graphic** ‘To be a Paralympian there’s got to be something wrong with you’ creates a **conceptual binary opposition** between audience perception of Paralympic athletes and the reality. It challenges how language is used set against the reality of the positive images in the advertisement. It is this opposition that the audience is encouraged to reflect upon. ‘The juxtaposition between being a Paralympic athlete at the peak of your powers and being unable to get in a cafe for a drink is pretty shocking. And tells the story in a very simple way.’

(<https://www.campaignlive.co.uk/article/theyve-nailed-again-channel-4-unveils-super-human-campaign-tokyo-paralympics/1722076>)

PART 2: STARTING POINTS – Representation

Product context:

Super. Human. is the third of Channel 4’s advertising campaigns for the Paralympic Games. It will be useful to look at the other two campaigns and consider the different approaches that have been taken by the channel in their representation of disability.

Launching the campaign, Lynsey Atkin, 4Creative’s Executive Creative Director, said: ‘Following the last two Paralympics adverts was no small task – they exploded attitudes around disability Yet we spotted an opportunity to present Paralympians in a way they hadn’t been shown before – by pointing a camera at the realities of their lives, and, as with any elite athlete, the sacrifices they make in pursuit of greatness. collectively these choices paint a story of mental determination, not of disability.’

(<https://www.televisual.com/news/watch-c4s-paralympics-campaign-super-human/>)

The decision was therefore made to change the focus of a previous campaign ‘Meet the Superhumans’ and instead in the 2020 campaign to emphasise the ‘Human’ rather than the ‘Super’ and to juxtapose the images of the training regime with those of the everyday lives of the athletes, with the intention of making them relatable to audiences.

Consider how and why particular social groups may be under-represented or misrepresented.

- Dominant groups in society largely control what is produced and as a result, minority groups tend to be marginalised, creating an unrealistic view of the contemporary world. This advertisement attempts to address the marginalisation of certain social groups, in this case, those with disabilities. Its aim, reflecting the ideology and ethos of Channel 4, is to give a voice to those who are not usually represented positively in other areas of the media.
- The positive representation of disability in the advertisement and the coverage of the games changed attitudes. According to YouGov research, 65% of viewers felt that the coverage of the Paralympics had a positive impact on their perceptions of disabled people. 82% of viewers agreed disabled athletes were as talented as able-bodied athletes (<https://www.campaignlive.co.uk/article/theyve-nailed-again-channel-4-unveils-super-human-campaign-tokyo-paralympics/1722076>).

Consider how representations are constructed through processes of selection and combination:

- Choices have been made by the producers of the advertisement to create representations that challenge accepted ideas regarding disability and disabled athletes in particular.
- The advertisement actively avoids negative stereotypical representations of Paralympians as victims to be pitied, or heroes, ‘superhumans’, to be viewed in awe. Instead, the representations create a realistic, ‘blood and guts’ feel to the advertisement. The representations cover both genders and give a different view of the world of disability to that of ‘having something wrong with you’.